

WHAT DOES IT TAKE TO BE A GLOBAL BUSINESS LEADER?

"Leadership is not about wealth but social purpose"

MUKESH AMBANI CHAIRMAN & MANAGING DIRECTOR, RELIANCE INDUSTRIES

Four years ago, the INDIA TODAY Conclave 2004 had the theme of 'Building an India Century.' And at that time, I had addressed the question, 'Can India become a G-5 economy?' Today in 2008, the conviction that India can very well become a G-5 economy is much stronger. Today I would like to address the question: How can India, as a country, join the ranks of world leaders? How Indian businesses could rise to global heights?

Before I present my main theme, I would like to make two preliminary observations. First, about the much-hyped talk, about the number of Indians in the world's billionaire list. This, in my view, is a deceptive distraction. It is like "Maya" of Indian philosophy. It veils your vision and comes in the way of knowing your real self. To all those who have aspirations of global leadership, I would like to caution: Beware of this titillating illusion.

I learnt from our founder-chairman Shri Dhirubhai Ambani, my father, and what I learnt has great relevance to the theme. Because, within one lifetime, Reliance rose from scratch, from a \$1,000 company to become India's number one private sector company; the first Indian private company in the Fortune Global 500 rankings; and a company which aspired for global leadership in all its major areas of businesses. The values, principles and the roadmap which enabled Reliance to achieve these heights have been tested in the teeth of tough competition and heavy odds.

Global leadership, in culture, knowledge, technology as well as business, is not something unknown in Indian history. Till as recently as 1700, India, China and Europe accounted for a similar share of world income. India enjoyed 25 per cent share of the global trade in textiles then. The annual revenues of the Moghul emperor Aurangzeb in 1659-1701 are said to have been more than 10 times those of his contemporary Louis XIV of France. By the early 18th century, India was a leading manufacturing country in the world. India, at that time, had a 22.6 per cent share of the

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